

Week 1, Tuesday: AI Ethics, Bias, and the Tool Landscape

Responsible AI and Navigating the Ecosystem

Mediacrest Training College Faculty

Mediacrest Training College

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Session Overview

Welcome to Tuesday's session of the AI and Machine Learning Foundation program. Today, we shift from "what AI is" to "how we use it responsibly and effectively."

- **Segment 1 (1.5 Hours): AI Ethics and Bias.** We will explore why data is the foundation of AI, how algorithms inherit human prejudices, and the core ethical pillars of AI deployment.
- **Segment 2 (1.5 Hours): Overview of AI Tools.** A high-level introduction to the free, browser-based toolkit we will use throughout this course, followed by a guided tour.

Session Objectives

By the end of this session, learners will be able to:

- Explain why data quality is the absolute foundation of any AI system.
- Recognize how AI bias occurs and identify real-world examples of algorithmic prejudice.
- Articulate the core ethical considerations in AI: privacy, transparency, and fairness.
- Navigate the basic interfaces of key generative AI tools (ChatGPT and Gemini).
- Understand the conceptual landscape of No-Code ML and Enterprise AI platforms.

Part 1:
AI Ethics and Bias

"With great computational power comes great responsibility."

Data: The Foundation of AI

The Core Principle

AI does not "know" anything inherently. It only knows what it has been shown.

- **Traditional Software:** Relies on explicit, human-written rules.
- **Machine Learning:** Relies entirely on **data** to find patterns and generate its own rules.
- **The Implication:** The quality, diversity, and representativeness of the training data directly dictate the performance and behavior of the AI model.

When Data is Flawed: Garbage In, Garbage Out

The GIGO Principle

If you feed an AI system flawed, incomplete, or skewed data, it will produce flawed, incomplete, or skewed outputs.

- **Incomplete Data:** Missing crucial demographic groups leads to blind spots.
- **Historical Data:** Reflects past societal inequalities, which the AI may learn and perpetuate.
- **Noisy Data:** Errors, duplicates, or mislabeled examples confuse the learning algorithm.

Understanding AI Bias

Definition

AI bias occurs when an algorithm produces systematically prejudiced results due to erroneous assumptions in the machine learning process.

- It is rarely intentional "evil code."
- It is usually the result of **unrepresentative training data** or **poorly defined optimization goals**.
- Bias can manifest in race, gender, age, socioeconomic status, and geographic location.

How Algorithms Inherit Human Prejudices

- **Historical Reflection:** AI trained on historical hiring data will learn that certain demographics were historically favored, and replicate that pattern.
- **Proxy Variables:** Even if you remove "race" or "gender" from the data, the AI might find proxies (e.g., zip code or university name) that correlate strongly with those protected attributes.
- **Feedback Loops:** A biased predictive policing algorithm sends more police to a specific neighborhood, generating more arrest data there, which further "confirms" the algorithm's bias.

Real-World Bias Example: Hiring & Recruitment

The Case

A major tech company built an AI recruiting tool to review resumes and rank candidates.

- **The Flaw:** The model was trained on 10 years of resumes submitted to the company, which predominantly came from men.
- **The Outcome:** The AI taught itself that male candidates were preferable. It began penalizing resumes that included the word "women's" (e.g., "women's chess club captain").
- **The Result:** The project was scrapped, but it highlighted the danger of using unvetted historical data.

Real-World Bias Example: Facial Recognition

The Case

Commercial facial recognition systems are increasingly used for security, authentication, and law enforcement.

- **The Flaw:** Many early systems were trained overwhelmingly on datasets of lighter-skinned male faces.
- **The Outcome:** Error rates for darker-skinned females were significantly higher (up to 34% in some early studies) compared to lighter-skinned males (under 1%).
- **The Impact:** Higher rates of false positives, leading to wrongful identifications and severe real-world consequences.

Ethical Considerations: Privacy

- **Data Collection:** Was the data collected with informed consent?
- **Data Usage:** Is the data being used for a purpose the user originally agreed to?
- **Data Protection:** Is personally identifiable information (PII) adequately anonymized and secured against breaches?
- **The Right to be Forgotten:** Can users request their data be removed from the training sets of AI models?

Ethical Considerations: Transparency

Explainability and the "Black Box" Problem

Users and stakeholders have a right to understand how an AI system arrived at a specific decision, especially in high-stakes domains like healthcare, finance, or criminal justice.

- **Opaque Models:** Deep learning models are often "black boxes" where the internal decision-making process is not easily interpretable.
- **The Goal:** Developing Explainable AI (XAI) that provides clear, understandable rationales for its outputs.

Ethical Considerations: Fairness

- **Equitable Treatment:** The AI system should not discriminate against individuals or groups based on protected characteristics.
- **Accessibility:** AI tools should be designed to be usable by people with diverse abilities and from diverse socioeconomic backgrounds.
- **Resource Allocation:** In public services, AI should not systematically disadvantage marginalized communities in the allocation of resources (e.g., loans, healthcare, housing).

The Business Case for Responsible AI

Ethical AI is not just a moral imperative; it is a business necessity.

- **Brand Reputation:** Unethical AI scandals cause severe, long-lasting damage to public trust and brand value.
- **Regulatory Compliance:** Governments worldwide are enacting strict AI regulations (e.g., the EU AI Act). Non-compliance leads to massive fines.
- **Better Products:** Diverse, unbiased data leads to more robust, accurate, and universally applicable AI products.

Mitigating AI Bias: Best Practices

Building Responsible AI

- **Diverse Teams:** Include ethicists, sociologists, and diverse demographic representatives in the AI development lifecycle.
- **Data Audits:** Rigorously test training datasets for representativeness and hidden biases before training begins.
- **Continuous Monitoring:** Regularly audit deployed models for "model drift" and emerging biases in real-world performance.
- **Human-in-the-Loop (HITL):** Ensure critical decisions are reviewed by humans, with AI serving as an assistive tool, not the final arbiter.

Part 2:
Overview of AI Tools

"Navigating the ecosystem of free, browser-based tools."

The Course Toolkit Overview

Throughout this program, we will use tools that are **free**, **browser-based**, and require **no complex local installation**.

- **Generative AI:** ChatGPT, Google Gemini, Microsoft Copilot.
- **No-Code Machine Learning:** Google Teachable Machine.
- **Enterprise/Platforms (Conceptual):** Automated Machine Learning (AutoML) and Microsoft Azure AI.

Note

You will need a stable internet connection and a Google Account to access most of these tools.

Generative AI: ChatGPT

Developed by OpenAI

One of the most widely used Large Language Models (LLMs), excelling in natural language understanding and generation.

- **Strengths:** Drafting text, summarizing documents, brainstorming, coding assistance, and role-playing scenarios.
- **Access:** Free tier available via web browser (chat.openai.com).
- **Course Use:** Our primary tool for learning prompt engineering and text-based AI interaction.

Generative AI: Google Gemini

Developed by Google

A multimodal AI model deeply integrated into the Google ecosystem.

- **Strengths:** Seamlessly handles text, images, and documents. Can analyze uploaded PDFs, images, and connect with Google Workspace (Docs, Gmail).
- **Access:** Free tier available via web browser (gemini.google.com).
- **Course Use:** Exploring multimodal capabilities and document analysis.

Generative AI: Microsoft Copilot

Developed by Microsoft

An AI assistant powered by advanced models (including OpenAI's technology), integrated across Microsoft products.

- **Strengths:** Web search integration (providing cited sources), image generation (via DALL-E), and deep integration with Windows and Microsoft 365.
- **Access:** Free tier available via web browser (copilot.microsoft.com) or Windows 10/11 sidebar.
- **Course Use:** Demonstrating AI with real-time web grounding and citation.

No-Code ML: Google Teachable Machine

Developed by Google

A fast, easy, and accessible way to create machine learning models for the web, entirely in your browser.

- **Strengths:** Requires zero coding. You can train a model to recognize images, sounds, or poses using your webcam or microphone in minutes.
- **Access:** Free via teachablemachine.withgoogle.com.
- **Course Use:** Demystifying how ML models learn from data by building a simple image classifier live.

Enterprise Platforms: AutoML (Conceptual)

What is AutoML?

Automated Machine Learning refers to tools that automate the end-to-end process of applying machine learning to real-world problems.

- **Target Audience:** Domain experts and business analysts with limited data science expertise.
- **How it works:** You upload a labeled dataset, and the platform automatically tests various algorithms, tunes hyperparameters, and selects the best-performing model.
- **Examples:** Google Cloud AutoML, DataRobot, H2O.ai.

Enterprise Platforms: Microsoft Azure AI (Conceptual)

What is Azure AI?

A comprehensive, cloud-based suite of AI and machine learning services provided by Microsoft.

- **Capabilities:** Ranges from pre-built cognitive services (e.g., Vision, Speech, Language) to custom model building via Azure Machine Learning Studio.
- **Enterprise Focus:** Built for scalability, security, compliance, and integration with existing corporate IT infrastructure.
- **Course Context:** We will not build in Azure, but understanding its role is vital for enterprise AI literacy.

Part 3:
Guided Tour & Hands-On Setup

"Getting your accounts ready for the week."

Guided Tour: Account Creation

Action Required Now: Please open your laptops and ensure you have access to the following.

1. **Google Account:** Required for Google Gemini and Teachable Machine. (If you don't have one, take 2 minutes to create it at accounts.google.com).
2. **Microsoft Account:** Optional but recommended for Microsoft Copilot.
3. **OpenAI Account:** Go to chat.openai.com and sign up or log in using your email or Google account.

Facilitator Note

Raise your hand if you encounter any login issues, and our assistants will come to help you.

Guided Tour: ChatGPT Interface

- **Sidebar (Left):** History of your past chat conversations. You can rename, delete, or start a "New Chat."
- **Main Window:** The conversation thread where AI responses appear.
- **Input Box (Bottom):** Where you type your prompts. Includes icons for attachments (in some tiers) and voice input.
- **Model Selector:** Top left, allowing you to switch between different model versions (e.g., GPT-4o, GPT-3.5).

Guided Tour: Gemini Interface

- **Sidebar (Left):** Recent activity and saved prompts.
- **Main Window:** Clean, conversational interface similar to ChatGPT.
- **Input Box (Bottom):** Features a prominent "+" button for uploading files (PDFs, images, spreadsheets) directly from your Google Drive or computer.
- **Google Integration:** Look for the "G" icon, which allows Gemini to double-check its responses against Google Search for real-time accuracy.

Hands-On Activity: Your First Prompt

Activity: Draft a Professional Email

Task: Open ChatGPT or Gemini and paste the following prompt:

```
Act as a professional project manager. Draft a brief, polite email to a client explaining that
    the project delivery will be delayed by 3 days due to unforeseen data quality issues. Offer a
     revised timeline and reassure them of our commitment to quality.

```

Observe: How does the AI structure the response? Is the tone appropriate?

Hands-On Activity: Teachable Machine Demo

Facilitator Live Demo:

1. Navigate to `teachablemachine.withgoogle.com`.
2. Select "Image Project" $\rightarrow$ "Standard Image Model".
3. **Class 1:** Hold up a pen to the webcam and click "Hold to Record" (gather 100+ samples).
4. **Class 2:** Hold up a phone (or another object) and record 100+ samples.
5. Click **"Train Model"** and watch the AI learn in real-time.
6. **Test:** Use the "Preview" pane to see if the model correctly identifies the objects.

Learners are encouraged to follow along on their own devices.

Tools & Requirements Checklist

To ensure a smooth hands-on experience for the rest of the week, please verify your setup:

- **Hardware:** Personal Laptop (Windows 10+ or macOS 10.15+).
- **Internet:** Stable broadband connection (5+ Mbps minimum).
- **Browser:** Latest version of Google Chrome, Microsoft Edge, or Firefox.
- **Accounts Verified:**
  - ✓ Google Account (for Gemini, Teachable Machine).
  - ✓ OpenAI Account (for ChatGPT).

Troubleshooting Common Setup Issues

Quick Fixes

- **"I can't log in to ChatGPT":** Clear your browser cache/cookies or try an Incognito/Private browsing window.
- **"Teachable Machine won't access my webcam":** Check your browser's address bar for a blocked camera icon and click "Allow". Also, check your OS privacy settings.
- **"The AI tool is running very slowly":** Ensure no heavy downloads are running in the background and that your internet connection is stable.

Key Takeaways: AI Ethics & Bias

- **Data is Destiny:** The quality and representativeness of training data dictate AI behavior. Flawed data leads to flawed outcomes (GIGO).
- **Bias is Real:** Algorithms can and do inherit human prejudices from historical data, leading to real-world harm if unchecked.
- **Ethical Pillars:** Responsible AI deployment must prioritize **Privacy** (consent/security), **Transparency** (explainability), and **Fairness** (non-discrimination).
- **Mitigation:** Diverse teams, rigorous data audits, and human-in-the-loop oversight are essential for building trustworthy AI.

Key Takeaways: AI Tool Landscape

- **Generative AI:** ChatGPT, Gemini, and Copilot are powerful, free, browser-based assistants for text, code, and multimodal tasks.
- **No-Code ML:** Tools like Teachable Machine democratize AI, allowing anyone to build and understand basic ML models without writing code.
- **Enterprise AI:** Platforms like AutoML and Azure AI provide scalable, secure environments for business-grade AI, building on the same foundational concepts we are learning.
- **You are now equipped** with active accounts and a foundational understanding of how to navigate these interfaces.

Q&A and Discussion

Open Floor

The floor is now open for questions.

Discussion Prompts (if time permits):

- Can you think of an AI tool you use daily that might have hidden biases?
- What ethical concerns do you have about using AI in your specific industry or field of study?
- Did anyone encounter any technical issues during the hands-on setup that we can solve together?

Wrap-up & Next Steps

- **Today's Takeaway:** You now have an awareness of AI's ethical boundaries and ready-to-use accounts for the week's practical tools.
- **Next Session (Thursday):**
  - **Data Basics:** We will dive into the practical side of data. Learn how to find, clean, and prepare datasets using Google Sheets/Excel.
  - **Hands-on:** We will use a real dataset to understand features, labels, and data preprocessing before feeding it to an ML model.

Mediacrest Training College
AI & Machine Learning Foundation Program
Nairobi, Kenya